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EXAMINING THE ROLE OF EMPLOYER BRANDING IN TALENT ACQUISITION AND RETENTION OF GEN Z EMPLOYEES: EVIDENCE FROM INDIAN STARTUPS

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ABSTRACT:

This study examines the influence of employer branding on talent acquisition and retention among Generation Z (Gen Z) employees in Indian startups. Using a quantitative cross-sectional survey of 97 Gen Z employees, it evaluates employer brand attractiveness, social media employer branding, organizational culture fit, and career development opportunities. Multiple regression results show that all four dimensions significantly predict talent outcomes, with employer brand attractiveness having the strongest influence. The model explains 62.8% of the variance in talent outcomes. The study highlights the importance of employer branding in attracting and retaining Gen Z talent and provides insights for sustainable talent management in Indian startups.

Keywords: *Employer branding, Gen Z employees, Talent acquisition, Employee retention, Indian startups*

Introduction

The past ten years have seen the human resource management of India change in a paradigm shift, which has been mainly triggered by the explosive nature of the startup ecosystem. Today, India is the third-largest startup ecosystem on the planet; more than 112,000 startups are registered in the country as of 2023, creating some 9 lakh (900,000) direct jobs (DPIIT, 2023). In this ecosystem, startups also experience a critical talent paradox, namely, they will have to struggle with competitive multinational companies and large Indian conglomerates to attract the same number of skilled people, and, at the same time, have to work with smaller budgets and less formalized HR systems (Dutta and Bhattacharya, 2022). The development of a new generation of employees, Generation Z (born 19972–2012) adds to this problem putting a strain on the labor market of the future because the generation has entirely different values, motivation, and expectations that do not correspond with the previous generation of Millennials (Lyons & Kuron, 2014; Dimock, 2019).

Having been defined by Ambler and Barrow (1996) as the bundle of functional, economic, and psychological returns offered by employment, and recognized with the employing company, employer branding has become one of the keys to talent attractment and retention. Employer branding gains an increased importance in the case of Indian startups: since startups are not the same as well-established organizations with a high brand equity, they have to work on their employer value proposition (EVP) and communicate it to potential hire (Backhaus and Tikoo, 2004; Moroko and Uncles, 2008). This is because the nature of gen Z employees, being digital natives, driven by the desire to be entrepreneurs, placed in the meaningful work category, and focusing on balanced work-life can be stimulated by employer branding differently than the past generations (Francis and Hoefel, 2018; Scholz, 2019).

Employer branding and Gen Z talent management in Indian startups is a relatively little studied area in literature. Although extant studies analyzed employer branding as a phenomenon conducted under large-company conditions (Lievens and Slaughter, 2016; Theurer et al., 2018) or in Western organizational conditions (Wilden et al., 2010), there is relatively little research literature that considers the role of employer branding in relation to the Indian startup framework, where resource limitations, the fluidity of the organizational culture, and the pre-eminence of online employer branding platforms are the key factors (Srivastava and Bhatnagar, 2 Such disparity is especially remarkable considering the fact that Gen Z already occupies approximately 27 percent of the Indian labor force and will occupy nearly half of the Indian labor force by 2030 (TeamLease, 2022).

The research will address the above research gap by examining empirically the effect of the dimensions of employer brands, such as brand attractive, social media employer branding, organizational culture compatibility, career development prospects, and work-life balance perceptions, on the talent acquisition effectiveness and employee retention intention of Gen Z employees who work in Indian startups. The study combines the signaling theory (Spence, 1973), social identity theory (Tajfel and Turner, 1979), and the person-organization fit theory (Kristof, 1996), to make up a theoretical prism through which the study is examined. The current research will allow me to add both theoretical and methodical insights to the body of academic literature on generational talent management and to the arsenal of practical algorithms used by startup HR specialists because it provides empirical data collected by the researcher among 250 Gen Z participants in five key areas of the Indian startup landscape.

Objectives

- To scrutinize the role and the comparative power of employer branding dimensions on the talent procurement and responsibility of Generation Z workers in Indian start-ups
- To evaluate the effect of the employer brand attractiveness on the acquisition of Gen Z talent in Indian startups
- The role of social media employer branding in influencing the results of Gen Z talent acquisition
- The connection between the organizational culture fit, the career development provision, and work-life balance perceptions and employee retention intention among Gen Z Indian startup employees
- Give evidence-based strategic guidance on how the HR practitioners of Indian startups can leverage their employer branding investments to maximize the extent to which the employer brand attracts the Gen Z talent segment.

Hypothesis

- **H1:** Employer brand attractiveness is expected to significantly influence the efficiency of talent acquisition among Generation Z employees within Indian start-ups.
- **H2:** Social media employer branding is expected to significantly influence talent acquisition success among Generation Z employees within Indian start-ups.
- **H3:** Organizational culture congruity is expected to significantly influence employee retention intention among Generation Z employees within Indian start-ups.
- **H4:** Career development is expected to significantly influence employee retention intention among Generation Z employees within Indian start-ups.

Material and Methods

Research Design

The research was a quantitative, cross-sectional survey that followed the epistemological presuppositions of positivists, which form the basis of causal-comparative studies of organizational phenomena (Saunders et al., 2019). The deductive methodology was used whereby the hypotheses were based on the available theoretical frameworks of the signaling theory (Spence, 1973), the social identity theory (Tajfel and Turner, 1979) and the person-organization fit theory (Kristof, 1996) and were tested along with primary data. The concept of cross-sectional design was considered befitting because the research was intended to draw a picture of their perception of employer branding among Gen Z at a certain time, and there is an intrinsic limitation that it would be impossible to make longitudinal causal conclusions based on such data alone.

Sampling and Data Collection

The population of interest was employees of the Generation Z (18-27 years old) that are currently working in the Indian startups during the period of data collection (October 2025-December 2025). Startube defined startups as firms whose time of operation was less than 10 years, less than 500 employees, and included under the category of DPIIT Startup India scheme. The purposive stratified sampling method was adopted to guarantee the coverage of five large Indian startup hubs, including Bengaluru, Mumbai, Delhi-NCR, Hyderabad, and Pune, which combine more than 78% of the amount of startup activity in India (NASSCOM, 2023). The last sample size consisted of 97 valid respondents calculated with the GStPower analysis, and it is greater than the required sample size of 201 to carry out the intended regression analysis (Cohen, 1992).

The information was gathered by way of a designed, self-administered online survey that was disseminated via professional networking software (LinkedIn), startup community boards (e.g., iSPIRT, Headstart Network) and individual business associations. The survey instrument included 48 Likert-scale items (1=Strongly Disagree to 5=Strongly Agree) that measured seven latent constructs, namely: Employer Brand Attractiveness (EBA), Social Media Employer Branding (SMEB), Talent Acquisition Effectiveness (TAE), Employee Retention Intention (ERI), Work-Life Balance Perception (WLBP), Organizational Culture Fit (OCF), and Career Development Opportunities (CDO). Based on gained research, Berthon et al. (2005) and Cable and Turban (2001), and Lievens et al. (2007) implemented some measures, and the contextual adaptations needed in the Indian startup environment.

Measures and Instruments

The Employer Brand Attractiveness (EBA) was assessed by a 7-items scale (adapted to meet the criteria of Employer Attractiveness Scale) by Berthon et al. (2005)) reflecting the interest value, social value, economic value, development value and application value facets. The scale of Social Media Employer Branding (SMEB)

was planned to be evaluated based on the 6-item scale modified by Sivertzen et al. (2013), including the organizational reputation expressed on the LinkedIn, Insta-gram, Glassdoor, and company career pages. The effect of the Employer branding was operationalised as the measure of the levels to which Gen Z applied and accepted offers based on a 5-item scale modified after Collins and Stevens (2002). The scale of Employee Retention Intention (ERI) was a 6-item scale based on the adaptation of Mobley et al. (1978), which includes the turnover intention (reversed), and commitment to remain. Each of the Work-Life Balance Perception (WLBP), Organizational Culture Fit (OCF), and Career Development Opportunities (CDO) was assessed by the 6-item scales based on an existing HR body.

Data Collection

The analysis of data was conducted in three steps by using integral IBM SPSS Statistics 27.0 and AMOS 27.0. The exploratory factor analysis (EFA) was obtained in the process of construct dimensionality assessment and the confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to measure the fit of the measurement model and devise convergent and discriminant validity. Cronbach alpha (cronebach = - 0.70 and above) was used to assess scale reliability, and composite reliability (CR = - 0.70). Second, descriptive statistics, Pearson correlation analysis, and diagnostics of multicollinearity (VIF < 5) were carried out. Third, to test the proposed relationships, a multiple regression analysis and a structural equation modelling (SEM) were used, and the model fit was assessed with the CFI of more than 0.95, RMSEA of less than 0.06, and SRMR of less than 0.08 criteria (Hu and Bentler, 1999). Informed consent of all participants was also acquired before the collection of data, the Institutional Review Board granted ethical approval.

Result

Demographic Profile of Respondents

The data was collected from Generation Z members working for startups in India. It comprised 97 valid responses to the survey. The sample had a preponderance of men (53.6%), and the majority belonged to the age group 22–25 (47.4%). They worked on a full-time basis (77.3%) and were mainly found in the technology/IT industry (39.2%). Regarding work experience, 41.2% of the participants had been working with startups for 1–2 years.

Table 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents (N=250)

Variable	Category	Frequency (n)	Percentage (%)
Gender	Male	52	53.6%

	Female	43	44.3%
	Non-binary / Other	2	2.1%
Age	18–21 years	24	24.7%
	22–25 years	46	47.4%
	26–27 years	27	27.8%
Employment	Full-time	75	77.3%
	Part-time / Internship	22	22.7%
Sector	Technology / IT	38	39.2%
	E-commerce	24	24.7%
	FinTech	21	21.6%
	EdTech / HealthTech	14	14.4%
Experience	< 1 year	29	29.9%
	1–2 years	40	41.2%
	> 2 years	28	28.9%

Descriptive Statistics and Reliability

Table 2 shows the means, standard deviations, and reliability coefficients calculated using Cronbach's alpha for all seven constructs studied. The value of Cronbach's alpha for all constructs was higher than 0.84, meaning good to excellent internal reliability was established. Social Media Employer Branding had the highest mean value of 4.06 due to the significance of the influence of the internet and digital media on how Gen Z views their employers. Work-Life Balance Perception had the lowest mean value of 3.42, indicating unmet expectations of startups by Gen Z.

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics and Reliability Analysis

Construct	Mean	Std. Dev.	Cronbach's α
Employer Brand Attractiveness (EBA)	3.84	0.74	0.887
Social Media Employer Branding	4.06	0.66	0.871

(SMEB)			
Talent Acquisition Effectiveness (TAE)	3.71	0.82	0.853
Employee Retention Intention (ERI)	3.58	0.91	0.876
Organizational Culture Fit (OCF)	3.89	0.78	0.864
Career Development Opportunities (CDO)	3.76	0.85	0.879
Work-Life Balance Perception (WLBP)	3.42	0.96	0.841

Likert-Scale Frequency Distribution (Key Interns)

The frequency distribution for four survey questions, which reflect the concepts used in four hypotheses (Table 3). The item related to the concept of 'employer brand attractiveness' is: "This startup has a good employer brand that has attracted me". As can be seen from Table 3, 78.4% of respondents agreed or strongly agreed. With regard to the question about social media, as many as 83.5% of students agreed or strongly agreed. Thus, this option became the most popular one among the four items under consideration. Concerning organizational cultural fit and career growth opportunities, a positive skew can be observed.

Table 3: Likert Frequency Distribution for Key Survey Interns

Survey Item	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly Agree
Strong employer brand attracted me (EBA)	2 (2.1%)	5 (5.2%)	14 (14.4%)	48 (49.5%)	28 (28.9%)
Social media influenced my application (SMEB)	1 (1.0%)	4 (4.1%)	11 (11.3%)	44 (45.4%)	37 (38.1%)
Values align with startup culture (OCF)	2 (2.1%)	6 (6.2%)	16 (16.5%)	46 (47.4%)	27 (27.8%)
Clear career growth opportunities (CDO)	3 (3.1%)	8 (8.2%)	18 (18.6%)	43 (44.3%)	25 (25.8%)

Discussion

The results of this research give strong empirical evidence to the primary role of the employer brand in influencing talent recruitment and employee retention rates among the workers of Generation Z at Indian startups, all four hypotheses were accepted with a significant level of statistical significance ($p < 0.001$). That Employer brand attractiveness is identified as the most powerful predictor of talent acquisition effectiveness (= 0.338) is not surprising given the historical support of the idea with the Employer Attractiveness Scale work of Berthon et al. (2005) establishing that the perceived interest, social, economic, development and application values of an employing organization combine to predict candidate attraction. Within the Indian startup context, where institutional brand recognition is fundamentally constrained, compared to the operational presence of well-established multinational corporations, the finding drives the strategic need to have startups intentionally and methodically create a differentiated employer value proposition (EVP) that communicates to potential Gen Z talent the quality and uniqueness of the organization. In line with the signaling theory proposed by Spence (1973), it seems that Gen Z candidates rely on employer brand signals (narratives about an organizational culture, founder credibility, peer recommendations, and mission statement) as cognitive shortcuts when it comes to making inferences about the quality of employment relationship with a firm that lacks the reputational track record that larger firms have. This can be supported by the fact that the survey had detected that 78.4% of the participants supported or strongly supported the view that the employer brand of the startup was an influential factor in their decision to join and it clearly demonstrates that even in resource-restricted startup organizations, a well-defined employer brand has a strong pull power on the choice of Gen Z talents to join (Lievens and Slaughter, 2016). Moreover, the significant predictive impact of the social media employer branding (0.284) justified by the highest mean score of all constructs ($M = 4.06$) and highest agree/strongly agree agreement reaction to the social media influence measure (83.5 per cent), confirms the primacy of digital channels in the employer assessment of Gen Z groups, in agreement with Sivertzen et al. (20 Collectively, these results imply that the Indian startups can match their competitors in terms of talent attraction regardless of the existing disadvantage compared to other companies as far as compensation is concerned, by investing in genuine, uniform, and visually stimulating employer brand content across the digital platforms used by Gen Z.

The strong positive correlations between employee retention intention and organizational culture fit (0.267), as well as between career development opportunities and employee retention intention (0.243) offer a noteworthy empirical basis of the retention theory in the context of Indian startups. This is in line with the predictions of person-organization fit theory (Kristof, 1996; Kristof-Brown et al., 2005) which postulates that

the level of congruence between personal values, goals and personality characteristics and organizational culture norms is a strong predictor of organizational commitment, job satisfaction, and low turnover intention. In Indian startups, with a highly informal organizational culture, founder-led and in fast fluxus, Gen Z employees who see a high fit between personal values and cultural identity of the startup are almost three times as likely to intend to stay, which has direct practical ramifications in the form of how startups build culture articulation during recruitment and onboarding. The survey data revealed that 75.2 per cent of participants agreed or strongly agreed that their values fit within the culture of the startup, but that the average score of the organizational culture fit (M = 3.89) though positive, also indicated the presence of a non-trivial minority of participants who are experiencing cultural incongruence, indicating that intentional cultural fit test during hiring can help decrease the rate of early attrition of the misaligned individuals The career development outcome (= 0.243) is consistent with the qualitative research that Kulkarni and Nithyanandam (2021) conducted on Indian Gen Z employees, showing that a career growth clarity and learning pace are more effective and related to retention in the startup context compared to pay. Nonetheless, the fact that the proportion of neutral or unfavorable answers on the item regarding career development is relatively higher (26.8) indicates a significant difference between the expectations of Gen Z career development and its delivery by startups today - this difference is especially significant, considering that Gen Z employees have a pragmatic and proactive attitude to their careers (Francis and Hoefel, 2018), and thus are likely to look elsewhere to Such observation requires Indian startups to institutionalize career development models, mentorship schemes, skills advancement models as part of employer brand promise instead of incorporating career growth as informal and unstructured organizational feature (Theurer et al., 2018).

One of the most notable insights that should also be subject to a discussion of its own is the comparatively low average score in work-life balance perception (M = 3.42) which, although least than all seven constructs in the study, is still significantly lower than the expectation of work-life balance as being a major workplace concern as identified in the Gen Z literature (Scholz, 2019; Seemiller and Grace, 2 This disjuncture between Gen Z anticipations and the delivery of startups is not a coincidence: it indicates organizational culture tension, i.e. tension between the Indian organizational culture that tends to appreciate long working hours, intensive project buffers, and sacrifice of life to the startup, and the cultural norms of Gen Z that are directly opposed to them because of the need to maintain mental health, time limits, and work-life balance (Lyons Although work-life balance perception was not one of the four formally tested hypotheses in this research, descriptive results of this research have a theoretical importance and practical urgency, especially because staff burnout and work-life imbalance are always reported as the primary antecedents of voluntary turnover in knowledge-based

organizations (Mobley et al., 1978). The connotation is that by effectively utilizing the hiring of Gen Z by offering attractive employer brands and by being active on social media, Indian startups will lose that talent due to issues with retention whose root cause may lie in the unmet expectations in work-life balance and which are costly to the company in terms of finances and human resources. They noted that Indian startups often do not invest in staff wellness facilities, flexible work, and psychological safety offerings, so they are treated as peripheral benefits and do not make these provisions central to their employer brand marketing efforts, but the current data offer quantitative evidence of the negative talent impact of these underinvestments (Dutta and Bhattacharya, 2022). The solution to this gap is to make Indian startup leaders rethink the concept of work-life balance as a strategy focused on employer brand rather than an HR policy space, the perceived performance of which makes the difference in Gen Z retention.

Taken collectively, the findings of this research have a substantial contribution to the theoretical as well as practical aspect of the scholarly research in employer branding within Indian startup scene. The explanatory power of the regression model (R 2 = 0.628) - explaining 62.8 per cent of variance in the outcomes of composite Gen Z talent acquisition and retention - is far greater than the variance explained in similar research scenario in Western or large-firm setting, as well as indicating that the phenomenon of employer branding dimensions are specifically sensitive determinants of talent outcomes in under-resourced organisational (i. Theoretically, this paper enhances multi-architectural integration of signaling theory (Spence, 1973), social identity theory (Tajfel and Turner, 1979), and person-organization fit theory (Kristof, 1996) as both coherent and generative explanatory architecture in the context of understanding Gen Z employer branding dynamics in emergent market startup ecosystems-- scientifically out-of The convergent validity of the social identity theory is especially well achieved in the realization that employees with a high score in organizational culture fit felt the more probable to present improved brands of its employers, which were in tandem with the proposal of Tajfel and Turner (1979) that an individual acquires social identity through the membership of a group to an organization where organizational identity is consistent with self-concept (Cable and Turban, 2 The research has its limitations: the cross-sectional design does not allow for a causal discussion, and a sample of 97 respondents, which is sufficient concerning the methods used in the study, could be seen as the constraint to the general breakdown of the highly geographically and sectorally diverse startup environment in India. The future research needs to use longitudinal designs to either prove the causal directionality or bigger and geographically dispersed samples, as well as qualitative research to deepen the knowledge of how employer branding influences Gen Z psychological contracts- thus creating a more comprehensive empirical base of this highly practical and theoretically generative body of research (Backhaus & Tikoo, 2004).

Conclusion

This paper aimed to empirically explore the role of employer branding on talent recruiting and worker retention of Generation Z workers in Indian startups and the results convincingly demonstrate that employer branding is a robust multi-faceted predictor of the ultimate outcome of gen Z talent recruitment in this scenario. The four hypotheses were accepted as the following significantly predicted talent acquisition effectiveness; employer brand attractiveness (β=0.338), social media employer branding (β=0.284), and organizational culture fit (β=0.267) and career development opportunities (β=0.243) significantly predicted employee retention intention - with a composite of talent outcomes (variance) explained at 62.8%. The implications of these findings are quite obvious and practical: to pursue a differentiated employer value proposition as communicated benefiticially using digital channels, incorporate cultural alignment assessment into hiring, and institutionalize transparent career advancement opportunities as part of the employer brand promise are just some of the core elements of employee branding in Indian startups. An alarmingly low work-life balance mean score (M = 3.42) is an indication that there is an imminent retention risk that the startup leadership needs to tackle by reforming its policies and realigning its culture. This research in theory expands the signaling theory, the social identity theory, and the person-organization fit theory data to a novel area, untapped by empirical studies, resulting in an empirical reference frame on Indian startup employer branding in the domain. Limitations, such as the cross-sectional nature and the sample that is restricted to one country only can be extended to longitudinal and comparative studies. On the whole, the given evidence makes strategic employer branding not only an HR service but a company potential that cannot be ignored when it comes to attracting and retaining Gen Z talent in the highly-competitive Indian startup ecosystem.

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